

Session 8: Blessing and Election in the Biblical Story

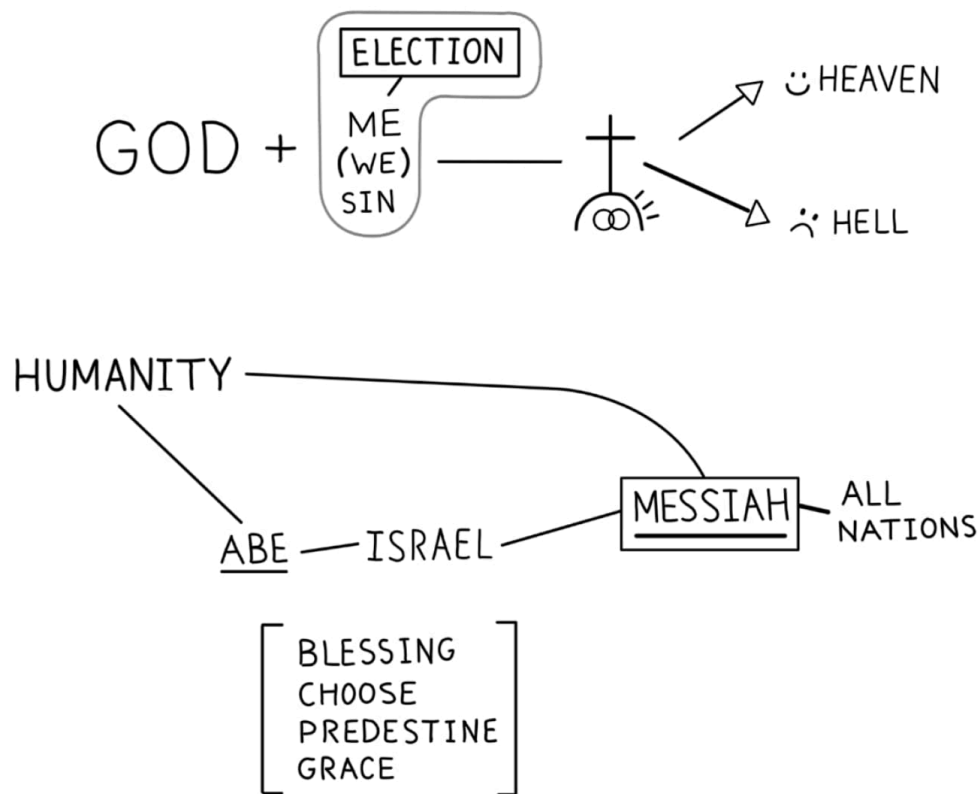
Key Takeaways

- We need to let Paul and the Hebrew Bible define what he means by the words he uses.
- Understanding Paul's view of the biblical story will help us understand his writings.
- Biblical election is about God choosing one out of the many to restore his blessing to the many.
- When Paul uses the words "election" and "predestination," he is referring to God choosing Israel as a vehicle to restore his blessing to the nations. Notice how Paul's concept of election is corporate—it is not referring primarily to individuals.

The Biblical Storyline of the Blessing

The key words of this blessing trace the development of the blessing through Israel's Scriptures so that the entire story focuses on the messianic realization of the blessing promised to humanity.

God's universal blessing and commission of the humans ([Gen. 1](#)) is forfeited through rebellion, so Abraham and his seed now bear the responsibility of covenant faithfulness as the family through which God will restore his blessing. Israel itself experiences God's blessing ([Exod. 1](#)) and is commissioned to represent God's holiness to the nations. As the nations fail, the seed of David is commissioned as the next carrier of that blessing ([2 Sam. 7](#)) so that the original plan of God's blessing for the nations can be fulfilled ([Ps. 72](#)). This narrative arc is core to the significance of Jesus' "incorporative messiah-ship." In Christ, people are invited to discover their identity as the new humanity in the family of Abraham. What is true of Jesus is now true of them.



Two Different Stories of the Bible. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

Humanity

Genesis 1:28 NASB

God **blessed** them; and God said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth, and subdue it; and rule over the fish of the seas and over the birds of the sky and over every living thing that moves on the earth."

Abraham

Genesis 12:2-3 NASB

² And I will make you a great nation,
and I will **bless** you,
and make your name great;
and so you shall be a **blessing**;
³ and I will **bless** those who **bless** you,
and the one who curses you I will curse.
And in you all the families of the earth will be **blessed**."

Genesis 22:17-18 NASB

¹⁷ indeed I will greatly bless you, and I will greatly multiply your seed as the stars of the heavens and as the sand which is on the seashore; and your seed shall possess the gate of their enemies. ¹⁸ **In your seed** all the

nations of the earth shall be **blessed**, because you have obeyed my voice.”

Israel

Exodus 1:1, 7 NASB

¹ Now these are the names of the sons of Israel who came to Egypt with Jacob; they came each one with his household ... ⁷ But the sons of Israel were fruitful and increased greatly, and multiplied, and became exceedingly mighty, so that the land was filled with them.

David's Messianic Line

2 Samuel 7:12-14, 29 NASB

¹² When your days are complete and you lie down with your fathers, I will raise up your descendant after you, who will come forth from you, and I will establish his kingdom. ¹³ He shall build a house for my name, and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever. ¹⁴ I will be a father to him and he will be a son to me ... ²⁹ Now therefore, may it please you to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For you, O Lord God, have spoken; and with your blessing may the house of your servant be **blessed** forever.

Psalms 72:17 NASB

May his name endure forever;
may his name increase as long as the sun shines;
and let men **bless** themselves by him;
let all nations call him **blessed**.

The Risen Jesus and the Spirit

Acts 2:14-36 and Acts 3:12-26 both speak to the risen Jesus being exalted to rule both Heaven and Earth. The gifting of the Spirit to the people spreads God's blessing to the nations as was promised to Abraham.

“God's purposes for the human race in general have devolved on to Abraham and from him onto Israel, through whom the divine plan will be fulfilled. Israel is, or is supposed to become, God's true humanity. What God intended for Adam will be given to the seed of Abraham, who will inherit a new Eden with its restored glory. ... [In Second Temple Judaism] the expectation for a Messiah was for one who would draw onto himself the hope and destiny of the entire people of Israel... The word Χριστός in Paul should regularly be read as 'Messiah,' and one of the chief significances that this word carries is incorporative, that is, it refers to the Messiah as the one in whom the people of God are summed up, so that they can be referred to as being 'in him,' as coming or growing 'into him.'”

Adapted from Wright, N.T. (1993). [*The Climax of the Covenant: Christ and the Law in Pauline Theology*](#). Fortress Press. 20-21, 25, 41.

Election and Predestination in Ephesians

Election and predestination must be understood in light of Paul's use of these terms in context of the biblical storyline that is focused on Israel and their covenant with Yahweh.

Israelite and Messianic Focus of Election Terminology

The primary referent of Paul's election language is Israel as the covenant family of Abraham.

Romans 9:4-5 Instructor's Translation

⁴ The Israelites, to whom belongs adoption and the glory and the covenants and the giving of Torah and the temple service and the promises, ⁵ to whom belong the patriarchs and from whom comes the Messiah in terms of his ethnic descent.

Romans 9:11 NASB

for though the twins were not yet born and had not done anything good or bad, so that God's purpose according to his choice would stand, not because of works but because of him who calls

God's election of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob was predestined (see [Rom. 9:6-13](#) for more).

Romans 11:2, 5 Instructor's Translation

² God has not rejected his people whom he foreknew (predestined) ... ⁵ So now in the present time, there is a remnant according to the choice/election of grace.

In Paul's view, the chosen covenant people are the chosen, elected, and predestined people of God, which now includes Jews and Gentiles who believe in Israel's Messiah, the true elect, chosen, and predestined one.

Romans 8:28-29 Instructor's Translation

²⁸ We know that for those who love God, he works all things toward good for those called according to his purpose, ²⁹ because those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, so that he would be the firstborn among many siblings ...

For Paul, the Messiah is part of God's eternal identity—the eternally elect, chosen, and beloved one. Because Jesus represents, incorporates, and embodies God's covenant people, those who trust in him will join the eternally chosen family of God.

Election Language Within the Biblical Storyline

God's eternal purpose is to bring his blessing to the world through the human family of Adam and Eve, then of Abraham, which is fulfilled in the Messiah. The calling/choosing/predestining of Abraham's family is narratively expressed in Genesis through Exodus and thematically expressed in Deuteronomy. Long before the Exodus generation lived, God planned for his people to inherit the promised land and become a blessing to the nations. The story of Israel is an analogy to the story of humanity in [Genesis 1-3](#). A human family will be united to God and inherit the cosmos to rule in the love and blessing of God.

The divine blessing celebrated in Ephesians 1:3-14 is the inclusion of the nations into the messianic Israel of the new exodus. All of the key words in the poem are adopted from descriptions of the patriarchs, Israel, and the Davidic Messiah. These images are applied to the Israel now restored “in Christ Messiah” (Eph. 1:3-12) and extended to the “believing Gentiles” (Eph. 1:13-14).

- “Spirit blessing” [see blessing chart above]
- “Chosen ... before the foundation of the cosmos”
- “Predestined us in love”

God’s Loving Choice of the Patriarchs and Israel

Deuteronomy 4:37 Instructor’s Translation

Because he **loved** our fathers, he **chose** their seed after them, and led them out of Egypt with a strong arm.

Deuteronomy 7:6-8 NRSV*

⁶ For y’all are a people holy to the LORD y’all’s God; the LORD y’all’s God has chosen y’all out of all the peoples on earth to be his people, his treasured possession. ⁷ It was not because y’all were more numerous than any other people that the LORD **set his heart on y’all** and chose y’all—for y’all were the fewest of all peoples. ⁸ It was because the LORD **loved** y’all and kept the oath that he swore to y’all’s ancestors ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Deuteronomy 10:15 NASB*

On y’all’s fathers, Yahweh **set his affection** to **love** them, and he chose their seed after them, y’all all, from among the peoples.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Deuteronomy 14:2 NIV*

For y’all are a people holy to the LORD y’all’s God. Out of all the peoples on the face of the earth, the LORD has chosen y’all to be his treasured possession.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

God’s Loving Choice of the Messianic Son

Psalms 89:19b-20, 24-29 NASB*

¹⁹ I have exalted one chosen from the people.

²⁰ I have found David my servant;
with my holy oil I have anointed him ...

²⁴ My faithfulness and my **covenant love** will be with him,
and in my name his horn will be exalted.

²⁵ I shall also set his hand on the sea
and his right hand on the rivers.

²⁶ He will cry to me, ‘You are my Father ...

²⁷ I also shall make him my firstborn,

the highest of the kings of the earth.

²⁸ My **covenant love** I will keep for him forever,
and my covenant shall be confirmed to him.

²⁹ So I will establish his seed forever
and his throne as the days of heaven.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Paul Describes Israel as the Predestined Family of God

Romans 9:11 Instructor's Translation

[Isaac is chosen] before doing good or bad, so that God's purpose, in accordance with his choice, might stand, not based on works, but on the one who calls.

Romans 11:2, 5 Instructor's Translation

² God has not rejected his people whom he foreknew (**predestined**) ... ⁵ So now in the present time, there is a remnant according to the choice/election of grace.

God's Loving Designation of Jesus as the Beloved, Predestined Son

Mark 1:11 Instructor's Translation

This is my Son, the beloved one, with him I am pleased.

John 17:24 NASB*

Father ... you loved me before the foundation of the world.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Paul's Inclusion of Gentiles into the Predestined Family of God

Ephesians 1:5 Instructor's Translation

Predestined for adoption as sons ...

Romans 8:28-29 Instructor's Translation

²⁸ ... those who are called, in accordance with his purpose, ²⁹ that those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be transformed together into the image of his Son ...

“For Sonship/Adoption”

Adam

God appoints humanity (Hebrew: *adam*) as the image of God (Gen. 1:26-28) to rule the world. In Genesis 5:1-3, Seth is the son of human “in his likeness according to his image,” so the human (Adam) in God's image is the firstborn son of God. See also Luke's genealogy of Jesus that calls Adam “the son of God” (Luke 3:38).

The “Adoption” of Sons in Genesis

God’s subversion of the firstborn custom and predestination of the second-born to high status is seen with the characters of Abel/Seth, Shem, Abram, Isaac, Jacob, Joseph, and Judah.

Israelites

Exodus 4:22-23 NASB*

²² Say to Pharaoh, “Thus says Yahweh, ‘Israel is my son, my firstborn. ²³ ... Let my son go that he may serve me’”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

David and His Seed

Psalms 89:20, 27, 29 NASB*

²⁰ I have found David, my servant ...

²⁷ I will make him my firstborn, the highest of the kings of the land. ...

²⁹ And I will establish his seed forever, and his throne as the days of the heavens.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Paul Describes Israel as the Adopted Ones

Romans 9:4 Instructor's Translation

the Israelites, to whom belongs adoption as sons

God’s Loving Adoption of Those Who Are “In the Messiah”

Ephesians 1:5 Instructor's Translation

... predestined for adoption as sons ...

Ephesians 2:19 Instructor's Translation

... members of God’s household

Galatians 4:5-6 ESV

⁵ ... so that we might receive adoption as sons. ⁶ And because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, “Abba, Father!”

Romans 8:15-16 NASB

¹⁵ ... you have received a spirit of adoption as sons, by which we cry out, “Abba! Father!” ¹⁶ The Spirit himself testifies with our spirit that we are children of God

“It is in the context of the role of Israel as the elect—chosen to provide God’s blessing and the Messiah—that Paul speaks of election [in Ephesians 1], rather than in the context of individual predestination to

salvation ... Paul asserts in this chapter that God's holy ones were 'chosen' to bring the blessing of redemption to all nations in fulfillment of the promise to Abraham. It was Israel that was foreordained unto adoption for this purpose ([Eph 1:5](#)), chosen in the beloved (i.e., the Messiah) for God's glory (i.e., to declare the sovereignty of Israel's God, [Eph 1:6](#)) before the foundation of the world to be holy and blameless ([Eph 1:4](#)) and to be the first ones to hope in the Messiah ([Eph 1:12](#))."

McRay, John (2007). [Paul: His Life and Teaching](#). Baker Academic. 339-340.

"The key to understanding what Paul means by [the word 'election'] is the phrase 'in Christ.' When Paul says believers were chosen before the foundation of the world 'in him,' ... He means that Christ preexisted before the creation of the universe and that, by God's choosing of him (who is the Elect One), those who would come to be 'in him' by faith find themselves among 'the elect' in the person of their redeemer. God, because of his great love, destined that those who believe 'in Christ' would be adopted as his sons and daughters. The concept of election and destining here is corporate. If one is in Christ, one is elect and part of the destined Messianic family. Paul is not talking about the pre-temporal electing or choosing of individual humans outside of Christ to be in Christ, but rather of the election of Christ and what is destined for those ... who are in Christ. The concept here is explicitly developed from the story of Israel's election: If someone was 'in Israel,' one was a part of God's chosen people. Individual persons within Israel could opt out by means of apostasy, and others, even non-Israelites could be grafted in by faith in Israel's God (see the story of Ruth). In [Ephesians 1:3-14](#), these biblical concepts of election are focused on Christ ... who can incorporate into himself those who trust in him. Christ has become the focal point of Israel's election and salvation, because in Paul's thinking the identity of the people of God has been whittled down to the story of Jesus the Anointed One and then built back up in the risen Christ thereafter. When Paul later speaks of how someone gets 'into Christ,' he does not speak of God's predestination, as though a person is programmed to be disposed towards faith. Rather, he says, 'in Christ, when you heard the word of truth, the good news ... you believed and were sealed by the Holy Spirit of promise' ([Eph 1:13](#))."

Witherington III, Ben (2007). [The Letters to Philemon, the Colossians, and the Ephesians: A Socio-Rhetorical Commentary on the Captivity Epistles](#). Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co. 233-235.

Paul's Presentation Contrasted With Other Jewish Sects

Paul's presentation of election and predestination stands in strong contrast to other Jewish communities in the Second Temple period who addressed the same topic. The sectarians of Qumran developed a very clear concept of double-predestination.

Damascus Covenant 2:6-8: "Those who turning aside from the path and abominate the precept, there will be for them no remnant or survivor. For God did not choose them at the beginning of the world, and before they were established he knew their deeds."

Garcia Martinez, Florentino & Tigchelaar, Eibert J.C. (2019). [The Dead Sea Scrolls Study Edition](#). Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co. 553.

Rule of the Community 3:13-17: "The Instructor should instruct and teach all the sons of light about the nature of all the sons of man ... concerning the times of their punishments and the times of their reward. From the God of knowledge stems all there is and all there shall be. Before they existed he established their entire design. And when they have come into being, at their appointed time, they will execute all their

works according to his glorious design, without altering anything. In his hand are the laws of all things and he supports them in all their affairs.”

Garcia Martinez, Florentino & Tigchelaar, Eibert J.C. (2019). [The Dead Sea Scrolls Study Edition](#). Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co. 75.

When Ephesians 1 is contrasted with the Dead Sea Scrolls, “Notice the total lack of discussion of the predestination of the wicked ... Ephesians does not depict election as that which divides the human race but as that which unites it in Christ, hence the strong contrast with the Qumran language about the election and salvation of the few righteous in contrast to the majority of the race.”

Perkins, Pheme (2000). “The Letter to the Ephesians.” *The New Interpreter Bible, Vol. XI*. Abingdon Press. 373.

“Even before creation God chose a people (in Christ) who would stand before him holy and blameless in love. Note that the thought here is not primarily of the election of individual people to the church (though that may be implicit), to be holy and blameless before him in the world (as at [Phil. 2:15](#)). The primary thought is rather that God eternally chose a people in Christ (us, i.e., the church), to be holy and blameless before him at the final judgment (as at [Col. 1:22](#), which is in Paul’s mind here), and so enter into the full blessings of the Messianic age, and new creation.”

Carson, D.A. (1994). “Ephesians.” [New Bible Commentary, 4th edition](#). Intervaristy Press. 1225.

“In Ephesians 1 Paul is not dealing with an abstract doctrine of double predestination in which God has chosen some for redemption and others for condemnation (note that the 'negative' side of double predestination is entirely absent in this passage). Rather, he is dealing with the scriptural story of God’s promises to Israel, now fulfilled in Christ and offered to the Gentiles who, like their Jewish brothers and sisters, may become inheritors if they receive God’s Messiah by faith.”

Thornhill, A. Chadwick (2015). [The Chosen People: Election, Paul, and Second Temple Judaism](#). IVP Academic. 223-224.

The New Exodus

Israel’s Redemption from Egyptian Slavery

Exodus 6:6 NASB*

I, Yahweh, will bring y’all out from under the burdens of the Egyptians, and I will deliver y’all from their slavery and I will also redeem y’all with an outstretched arm

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Exodus 12:13 NASB

The [Passover Lamb’s] blood shall be a sign for you on the houses where you live; and when I see the blood I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you when I strike the land of Egypt.

See more in [Exodus 13](#)

Exodus 15:13 Instructor's Translation

In your covenant love you have led the people whom you have redeemed, guiding them to your holy dwelling place.

Israel's Exile Is a New Slavery Because of Their Sins

Ezekiel 39:23 NASB

The nations will know that the house of Israel went into exile for their iniquity because they acted treacherously against me, and I hid my face from them.

Deliverance From Babylonian Exile as a New Exodus

Isaiah 11:11-16 NASB

¹¹ Then it will happen on that day that the Lord will again recover the second time with his hand the remnant of his people, who will remain, from Assyria, Egypt, Pathros, Cush, Elam, Shinar, Hamath, and from the islands of the sea.

¹² And he will lift up a standard for the nations and assemble the banished ones of Israel, and will gather the dispersed of Judah from the four corners of the earth.

¹³ Then the jealousy of Ephraim will depart, and those who harass Judah will be cut off; Ephraim will not be jealous of Judah, and Judah will not harass Ephraim.

¹⁴ They will swoop down on the slopes of the Philistines on the west; together they will plunder the sons of the east; they will possess Edom and Moab, and the sons of Ammon will be subject to them.

¹⁵ And the LORD will utterly destroy the tongue of the Sea of Egypt; and he will wave his hand over the River with his scorching wind; and he will strike it into seven streams and make men walk over dry-shod.

¹⁶ And there will be a highway from Assyria for the remnant of his people who will be left, just as there was for Israel in the day that they came up out of the land of Egypt.

Hosea 2:14-15 NASB

¹⁴ Therefore, behold, I will allure her, bring her into the wilderness

and speak kindly to her.

¹⁵ Then I will give her her vineyards from there,
and the valley of Achor as a door of hope.
And she will sing there as in the days of her youth,
as in the day when she came up from the land of Egypt.

The New Exodus as a Forgiveness From Sin

Israel's new exodus will require a redemption from slavery to sin and evil and the making of a new covenant.

Jeremiah 31:31-34 NASB

³¹ "Behold, days are coming," declares the LORD, "when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah, ³² not like the covenant which I made with their fathers in the day I took them by the hand to bring them out of the land of Egypt, my covenant which they broke, although I was a husband to them," declares the LORD. ³³ "But this is the covenant which I will make with the house of Israel after those days," declares the LORD, "I will put my law within them and on their heart I will write it; and I will be their God, and they shall be my people. ³⁴ They will not teach again, each man his neighbor and each man his brother, saying, 'Know the LORD,' for they will all know me, from the least of them to the greatest of them," declares the LORD, "for I will forgive their iniquity, and their sin I will remember no more."

The New Covenant Family

Adam and Eve

Genesis 3:6 NASB*

When the woman saw that the tree was ... desirable to give wisdom [regarding "good and evil"], she took from its fruit and ate, and she gave also to her husband and he ate.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Humanity's fundamental sin is the choice to seize our own wisdom.

Joseph

Genesis 41:38-39 NASB*

³⁸ Pharaoh said to his servants, "Where can we find a man like this, in whom is the Spirit of God/gods?" ³⁹ ... There is no one so discerning and wise as you are!"

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Joseph is also given wisdom (to rule the nations) by God's Spirit.

Torah

Deuteronomy 4:5-6 NASB

⁵ See, I have taught you statutes and judgments ... ⁶ So keep and do them, for that is your wisdom and your understanding in the sight of the peoples who will hear all these statutes and say, "Surely this great nation is a wise and understanding people."

The Son of David

1 Kings 3:7-12 Instructor's Translation

⁷ "... I am but a child ... ⁹ give to your servant a heart that listens, to rule judge your people to discern between good and evil ..." ¹¹ God said to [Solomon], "... Behold, I have given you a wise and discerning heart ..."

The Seed of David

Proverbs 3:13, 18 Instructor's Translation

¹³ How blessed is the one who finds wisdom,
the one obtains discernment. ...

¹⁸ She is a tree of life to those who take hold of her,
and those take her are blessed.

Messiah: The Incarnate Wisdom of God

1 Corinthians 1:24 NASB*

... the Messiah is both the power of God and the wisdom of God.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Colossians 2:3 NASB*

[Messiah] in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

God's Plan to Unite Heaven and Earth in the Messiah

Paul views Jesus' story as the cosmic climax to the story of the universe which began in Genesis.

In Genesis, humanity was called to rule over a unified Heaven and Earth in Eden ([Gen. 1-2](#)), but they forfeited that calling by falling prey to sin and rebellion ([Gen. 3](#)). The hope of an exalted humanity ruling over a unified Heaven and Earth became attached to the line of David ([Ps. 8](#)) and was projected forward after the exile into a cosmic future hope of the Son of Man ([Dan. 7](#)).

This storyline is brought together in Ephesians 1:9-10 in a dense theological statement that underlies the message of the entire letter.

Ephesians 1:9-10 Instructor's Translation

⁹ ... having made known to us the open secret of his will, in accordance with his purpose having been predestined in accordance with the plan of the one who works all things according to the decision of his will, which he preplanned in him, ¹⁰ for the purpose of arranging the fullness the times, to **head up all things** together **in Messiah, things in the heavens** and **things in earth** in him ...

“To head up all things”

“To head up all things” (Greek: ἀνακεφαλαιόω), or to bring into unity and harmony, assumes that the cosmos is fragmented and broken and needs to be put back into an ordered unity. Jesus is the one in whom all things find their purpose and healing. This is why Paul constantly uses words like “make one,” “unify,” and “together” (Eph. 1:10, 22; 2:14-16, 18; 3:6; 4:1-7, 13; 5:31).

Paul also uses this verb in Romans 13:9-10. “You shall not commit adultery, you shall not murder, you shall not steal, you shall not covet. And if there is any other commandment, it is summed up in this saying, ‘You shall love your neighbor as yourself.’ Love does no wrong to a neighbor; therefore love is the fulfillment of the law.”

“Christ is the one in whom God chooses to sum up the cosmos, the one in whom he restores harmony to the universe ... [T]he stress is placed on the one in whom God’s overarching purposes for the whole of the created order are included ... a universe that is centered and reunited in Christ. The mystery which God has graciously made known refers to the summing up and bringing together of the fragmented and alienated elements of the universe (‘all things’) in Christ as the focal point.”

O’Brien, Peter T. (1999). *The Letter to the Ephesians*. Eerdmans. 59.

“In Messiah”

Jesus is the ultimate human, whose death and resurrection redeemed humanity from sin (Eph. 1:7, 14) so that anyone who turns to him in faith (Eph. 2:8-9) is joined to his life transforming power (Eph. 2:5-6; 4:20-24). Paul constantly refers to God accomplishing all this “in Christ.” And he says that followers of Jesus find their true identity “in him” (he uses these phrases over 20 times!).

“Things in Heaven”

Spiritual beings and powers that were in rebellion against God and humanity (Eph. 2:1-3) have been defeated by Jesus (Eph. 1:21-22; 4:8). The creation of a new humanity in Jesus points to the subjugation of these spiritual powers (Eph. 3:9-10). These powers are still in rebellion and must be resisted by God’s power (Eph. 6:10-19).

“Things on Earth”

Earth is the human realm where people once estranged from God are now reconciled to him through Jesus (Eph. 2:1-10) and reconciled to each other (Eph. 2:11-18). The Jew and Gentile divide is the essential biblical image of humanity divided (Eph. 2:14-18), and they are now unified as one church by the Jewish Messiah (Eph. 2:19-22).

“Paul’s view of heaven was derived ultimately from the opening statement of the OT. ‘In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth’ (Gen. 1:1). Created reality had two major parts. That part known as the

heavens could be thought of in terms of the atmospheric heaven (e.g., [Ps. 147:8](#)) or firmament (e.g., [Gen. 1:7, 14](#)). As the upper part of the cosmos it also came to stand for the dwelling-place of God, pointing beyond its own createdness to the divine transcendence (e.g., [Ps. 2:4](#)). Not only so, but the upper limits of the firmament were regarded as concealing a presently invisible created spiritual order (e.g., [2 Kgs. 6:17](#); [Job. 1:6](#); [Zech. 3:1](#)). Here heaven had a priority as the upper and controlling element and yet in its created aspect it was involved in God's plan for the ages, for in Yahweh's acts of judgment the heavens as well as the earth are shaken (cf. [Isa. 51:6](#); [Amos 8:9](#); [Hag. 2:6](#) and [Isaiah 65:17](#) and [66:22](#)) can speak of the creation of a new heaven and a new earth, pointing to cosmic renewal. In Ephesians ... 'the heavenly realms' ... have reference to heaven as a distinct part of the created universe but one which retains its concealing relation to the spiritual world and to God himself, and thus also its aspect of incomprehensibility. The reference is to this heaven as it takes its place in the cosmic drama of redemption, that is, in that act of the drama which Christ has inaugurated by his resurrection and exaltation. Since Christ is central in God's plan for heaven, the Church 'in Christ' also plays a vital part in this realm. As we shall see, 3:10 and 6:12 take their place naturally within this definition of the formula, for heaven is still involved in this present evil age with the consequence that there will remain hostile powers in heaven until the consummation brings in the fullness of the new age with its reconciled and renewed cosmos."

Lincoln, Andrew T. (2004). [*Paradise Now and Not Yet: Studies in the Role of the Heavenly Dimension in Paul's Thought with Special Reference to His Eschatology*](#). Cambridge University Press. 140-141.

"To the Jew first, and then to the Greek"

Note the explicit shift in pronouns from "we" in vv. 3-12 to "you" in v. 13 and back to "we" in v. 14. The "we" is described as "those who first hoped in the Messiah" (Eph. 1:12), and the "you" refers to those who "believed and were sealed by the promised Holy Spirit" (Eph. 1:14). This is precisely the roadmap of the book of Acts, where messianic Jews were the first to believe and then, through the Holy Spirit, non-Jews were included.

"The key to understanding Ephesians 1 is found in the use of the pronouns of personal address. Who is the 'I,' who are the 'we,' and who are the 'you all' repeatedly referred to in these chapters? Scholars agree that one of the central issues addressed in this letter is that of a growing multiplication of Gentile converts who at best increasingly forget or at worst consciously dismiss the church's Jewish-Christian roots. What often gets overlooked is that Paul is tackling this matter right from the start. Indeed Ephesians 1-2 are less about how individuals are saved than about the multi-ethnic nature of God's new covenant people in Israel's Messiah."

Adapted from Haberer, Jack (2008). "Ephesians 1:15-23." *Interpretation* Vol. 62, No. 3. 312.

"Paul is telling or reminding the Ephesians that through Christ they have become participants in God's election of Israel, when God chose Abraham from among all people and graciously made a covenant with him. One of the reasons for God's call of Abraham and the establishment of an everlasting covenant with him is to bring a blessing to the nations (cf. Gen 12:1-3). Because of what God does with Israel, all the nations are to be drawn to God. As Isaiah, among others, declares, this will happen when Israel is redeemed ([Isa 2:1-4](#); [Amos 9:11-12](#)). In [Acts 15:15-17](#), James reads Amos as announcing the incorporation of Gentiles into the people of God ... And this is precisely what Paul is saying has happened in the death and resurrection of Israel's Messiah."

Fowl, Stephen E. (2012). [*Ephesians: A Commentary*](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 39.

Reflection Question

Summarize what “election” and “predestination” seem to refer to here in Ephesians 1. How have you typically understood these words? How have you heard them used?